The Watts Experiment

By Adriel Luis

We have TWO SUBJECTS of observation
(and we don't really need to give them names because
they'll both be dead by the end of the poem)
So we'll just label them as follows:
SUBJECT A is a 16-year-old black man
with a broken lisp.
At age 12, sirens blared his name and six pigs
surrounded.
Open palms to back of brown-flesh skull
Legs spread waist-length
See, SUBJECT A fit the description. But not knowing
so, he asked the cop
"What did I do wrong???"
But answered to baton against back of knees,
toppled body
Tooth cracked on concrete
And since then, SUBJECT A hasn't been able to
pronounce his words correctly.

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His tongue stumbles over words with the "s" sound
helplessly.
Words like "strength." And "soul." And "happiness."
So no one takes SUBJECT A seriously when he speaks.
But not like anyone ever really did.
SUBJECT B is a 43-year-old Korean man
(and I think you know where this is going)

INTRODUCTION

A little history . . . Watts is a neighborhood in southern Los Angeles. Longstanding resentment by Los Angeles's working-class black community over discriminatory treatment by police and inadequate public services (especially schools and hospitals) exploded on August 11, 1965, into what were commonly known as the Watts riots. Between 1989 and 2005, police reported more than 500 homicides in Watts, most of them gang-related and tied to wars over control of the lucrative illicit market created by illegal drugs. This poem was penned during that time and is a tragic tale about Black and Asian conflict in the neighborhood known as Watts.

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The scent of freedom was strong enough to coax a family of 3 across the Pacific. But now SUBJECT B sells bubble gum and beer in a corner store in Watts. He hands people change through a bullet-proof face.

Folks always wonder why Mr. Subject B won't smile.

But after 17 years of wiping down the same dingy iron-bar window, there's just not much to be happy about.

But hey, he can't complain.

He sells enough Coca-Colas to pay the rent. And he sells enough lottery tickets to put food on the table.

His 18-YEAR-OLD-SON has been helping him out for the past 12 years, stocking liquor bottles in refrigerated cases. Ever since he was forced into this dust-ridden store. SUBJECT B has been dreaming of rice terraces that his eyes won't ever kiss again. Dreaming of the home village where his name meant something.

But like I said

we're not paying attention to names this time.

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Today the sky cringes with smog and brokenness. Rusty copper bells rattle as SUBJECT A enters the store. It's hot, so he grabs a Coke and a Snickers bar for his girl. (It isn't the fanciest anniversary present, but he's adding a home-made slow jams mixtape so the gift will have some character.)

SUBJECT B watches him from the counter. Despite the fact that he recognizes every Black face that enters the store, he can't help but be nervous.

Because of the taunts. Because of the anger.

Because of the **BLACK FISTS** that picketed his store

2 weeks back,

when the **Black-owned** store

2 blocks down

closed.

"THESE DAMNED KOREANS

NEED TO GET OUT OF

OUR NEIGHBORHOODS!"

His ears echo their cries that swore that these rallies were fueled by a love that these foreign exploiters

can't feel. But SUBJECT B gave up his home so his son could eat a hot meal. SO if that's not love, then what is?

SUBJECT A has been standing there for a while now.

SUBJECT B scrambles for the words but he just can't piece them together. He doesn't mean to be rude, but it's the only English mood that he's ever been taught.

SUBJECT B: **Buy now or get out!**

Buy now or get out!

SUBJECT A doesn't want to hear it. He's been labeled as a thug inappropriately one too many times. Their eyes touch once.

SUBJECT A: **What's your problem, man?????**

SUBJECT A is pissed.

SUBJECT B is scared.

SUBJECT A steps forward.

SUBJECT B grabs the nine from behind the counter –

DEAD AIM ON BLACK MAN.

SUBJECT B (gun cocked back, sweat drips, fist shakes):

Get out now!

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But SUBJECT A has never been one to punk out like that.

SUBJECT A (takes another step forward):

I have money, see?

I have money, see??

But both can't understand the words coming out of the other's mouth.

2 subjects

2 speech impediments

Struggling over 1 language

Demonstrating 500 years of socialization.

Shouts continue, sirens approach. With all the commotion, SUBJECT B's 18-YEAR-OLD-SON bursts in through the back, gun in hand --

DEAD AIM ON BLACK MAN.

Shouts continue

Sirens approach

18-year old son

Gun in hand

Shouts continue

Sirens approach

18-year old son

Gun in hand

. . . TWO SHOTS FIRED

But SUBJECT A is thinking 2 seconds ahead.

He jumps aside and

SUBJECT B takes 2 bullets to the chest.

Dead silence.

Sirens approach.

18-year-old-son.

Gun in hand.

Dead silence.

Sirens approach.

Rusty copper bells

PIGS enter.

OLD KOREAN MAN down.

BLACK MAN standing.

6 shots fired.

BLACK MAN down.

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Red and blue spotlights. Cameras in the sky. Another story of Black and Asian conflict. Tonight, the sky bleeds of distortion. The news will paint a picture of it. The 2 SUBJECTS will be replaced. The scene will play again.

This is the Watts Experiment. Thank you for watching.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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